

Intermediate cartridge Medium-sized ammunition primarily used in *assault rifles*.

Ironclad A mid-19th-century warship with a hull built from, or protected by, iron plates.

Jian A Chinese sword with a long, straight blade with two edges.

Katana The long sword carried by a *samurai*.

Knot A unit used to measure a ship's speed. One knot equals one nautical mile per hour.

Lamellar A type of armour made of small plates laced together.

Langet A strip of metal secured along the length of a wooden staff weapon to reinforce the wood.

Light cruiser A cruiser typically equipped with 6in guns.

Light machine-gun A *machine-gun* chambered for *rifle-calibre* ammunition, but not capable of sustained fire.

Line of battle The formation of a fleet before entering into battle, traditionally a line.

Limber A simple trailer attached to a gun carriage.

Mace A medieval staff weapon with a spiked or flanged head.

Mach number The ratio of an aircraft's speed to the speed of sound. Mach 2, for example, is twice the speed of sound.

Machicolation An opening in a castle wall through which missiles could be dropped on an invading enemy.

Machine-gun An *automatic weapon* intended for sustained fire.

Machine pistol A pistol capable of automatic or select fire.

Magazine The part of a firearm that holds the ammunition; a storage area for ammunition in a building or on board a ship.

Mangonel A type of medieval siege catapult.

Matchlock A firing mechanism incorporating a piece of cord (or "slow-match") that ignites the *primer* when the trigger is pulled.

Medium machine-gun A *machine-gun* chambered for *rifle-calibre* ammunition and capable of sustained fire.

Mine An explosive laid beneath the surface of the ground or left floating on or just below the surface of the water.

Minesweeper A ship used for clearing *mines* at sea.

Miquelet A type of *snaphaunce* firing mechanism prevalent in the Mediterranean between the late-16th and mid-19th centuries.

Misericorde A long, narrow knife used in medieval times to deliver the "mercy stroke" to a mortally wounded knight.

Morion A 16th-century helmet with a flat or swept brim, and either a comb along its centre line or a "pearstalk" at its apex.

Mortar A high-angle, short-ranged artillery piece.

Muzzle The open front end of a firearm's barrel.

Musket A term originally used for a large and heavy firearm shot from a rest, that, from the 18th century, described a *smooth-bore* longarm gun.

Naginata A Japanese infantry *polearm* with a curved blade.

Optical sight A sighting device providing a single point of aim and often a degree of magnification.

Ordnance The collective term for cannon and artillery.

Orlop deck The lowest deck of a ship.

OSS The Office of Strategic Services, a World War II covert US intelligence service.

Paravane A device towed by a ship to destroy *mines* in the water.

Pennon A banner or streamer borne on a cavalryman's lance.

Percussion cap A firing mechanism with a small cap containing *fulminate* that serves as a primer in *muzzle-loading* firearms.

Phalanx An Ancient Greek military formation of heavy infantry armed with spears.

Pike An infantry weapon with a pointed metal head fixed on a long, wooden shaft.

Plate armour Armour made of articulating metal plates.

Pommel A counterweight at the top of a sword grip.

Pocket battleship A term that was given to three small but heavily armed German cruisers: *Graf Spee*, *Deutschland*, and *Admiral Scheer*.

Poleyn The part of medieval and Renaissance armour that protected the knee.

Pre-dreadnought A type of *battleship* with mixed heavy and medium main armament.

Primer The small amount of *fulminate* lit by a firing mechanism to ignite the main charge in the barrel; another word for *percussion cap*.

Privateer A private vessel used to raid enemy shipping in war.

Quillons Extended cross-guards on either side of a sword or knife blade designed to protect the hand.

Radar An instrument used to locate an object by transmitting and measuring radio waves.

Rapier Usually a thrusting sword with a long blade.

Rating An enlisted member of a navy.

Repeating rifle A *rifle* that can discharge multiple consecutive shots.

Revolver A gun which carries ammunition in a rotating cylinder.

Rifle A long-barrelled firearm with spiral grooves in the barrel.

Rolling barrage A continuous firing of artillery shells.

Rondel See *besagew*.

Rondel dagger A late-medieval European dagger with a round hand guard, and *pommel*.

Rotary cannon A revolving, multi-barrelled gun that provides a greater rate of fire than a single-barrelled gun of the same *calibre*.

Running rigging The part of a sailing vessel's rigging that controls the movement of the sails.

Sabaton Foot-covering armour.

Sallet A 15th-century helmet featuring a tail to protect the neck.

Samurai A member of military and political aristocracy in pre-industrial Japan.

Sap A deep, narrow trench used to approach or undermine an enemy position.

Sapper A combat engineer.

Scabbard A sword's sheath, terminating in a *chape*.

Scimitar An Islamic sword with a curved blade.

Scramasax See *seax*.

Seax A single-edged blade used by Anglo-Saxons and Franks as both a weapon and a tool.

Shaffron Protective armour for a horse's head.

Shako A tall, peaked hat adorned with a feather or pompom, worn by European and US soldiers.

Shamshir A type of *sabre* that spread from Persia from the 16th century onwards. It has a deep curve and tapers to a point.

Ship of the line A sailing warship, usually of a third-rate class vessel with 74 guns. See also *first-rate ship*.

Shrapnel shell A projectile containing a number of small bullets that explodes just before impact.

Silencer A device that reduces, but rarely silences, the sound, flash, and recoil of a fired round; for this reason, it is also known as a suppressor or moderator.

Skirmisher An infantryman or cavalryman who harasses the enemy in an irregular fashion.

Sloop A sailing vessel with a single mast and fore-and-aft rig; any minor class of warship.

Smart weapon A precision-guided munition directed to its target using laser guidance or GPS.

Smooth-bore A gun barrel lacking a rifled interior.

Snaphaunce An early *flintlock* mechanism featuring a separate pivoting striking surface made of steel, and a sliding pan-cover.

Sonar An electronic device used primarily by submarines to locate underwater objects.

Sponson A semi-circular gun turret on the side of a tank.

Staff weapon A type of weapon mounted on a long wooden or metal haft.

Standing rigging Fixed rigging that supports a ship's sails.

Stock The portion of a firearm that is held by the person firing it; it is attached to the lock, which holds the sparking mechanism, and the barrel, which carries and guides the explosive-driven shot or bullet.

Strakes The long planks forming the hull frame of a Viking longship.

Strategic bombing The planned destruction of specific targets with the intention of weakening the economy of an enemy state and the morale of its people.

Submachine-gun A hand-held *automatic weapon* firing *pistol-calibre* rounds.

Talwar A curved Indian sword.

Tang The part of a sword or knife that extends inside the grip.

Tanto A traditional Japanese short sword or dagger.

Tomahawk A North American Indian axe; a type of US cruise missile.

Tracer bullet A bullet treated with illuminant to show its direction and range.

Trebuchet A siege machine employing either manpower or counterweights to launch missiles.

Trireme An ancient Greek or Roman war galley, propelled by three tiers of oars on each side.

Turbocharger A device that compresses air into the combustion chamber of an engine to increase power and efficiency.

Turtle ship A 16th-century Korean armored warship that was fitted with an iron cover to prevent boarding by the crew of enemy ships.

U-boat (*Unterseeboot*) A German submarine.

Vambrace Armour that was developed in the 14th century to protect the forearm; from the 5th century it was designed to cover the whole of the arm.

Vervelles Metal staples used to attach an *aventail* to a helmet.

Visor A face defence attached to a helmet to protect the eyes.

Volley gun A multi-barrelled gun that fires several rounds at the same time.

Wakizashi A 30–60cm (12–24in) short sword that was worn by *samurai*.

Warhammer A medieval close-combat weapon with a handle of varying lengths.

Warhead The explosive material delivered by a rocket, missile, bomb, or torpedo.

Wheellock The first self-igniting firearm. It featured a friction-wheel that created a spark that lit the charge when the trigger was pulled.

Wolf pack A term used for a group of German submarines during World War II.

Yard The wooden spar perpendicular to the mast, from which a ship's sails are hung.

Yari A traditional straight-bladed Japanese spear.

Zeppelin Any of the airships built by the Zeppelin company; a generic term used for airships.